Become a **CRITICAL THINKER**

Understanding why critical thinking is so important is the first step to becoming a critical thinker.

Before we get into the topic, I would like, first, to wholeheartedly, acknowledge my two former and inspiring General Managers, Jurgen Fischer and Peter Alatsas, from whom I have learned a lot regarding their wisdom, techniques and approaches to Creative Management and Critical Thinking, over the period I have worked under their direct administration, as well as my professors at Cornell University, School of Hotel Administration.

The current flow of data and information available to people and organizations, due to evolving technology, invites us to think things through several times before we get convinced by it. People normally believe something based on a combination of factors and influences such as:

- personal experience;
- social and cultural influences;
- education and learning;
- religion and spirituality;
- media and information sources;
- personal values and biases;
- critical thinking and rationality;
- emotional influences;
- personal intuition and gut feelings; and
- peer pressure and social conformity.



FROM EGYPT

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Critical thinking and the evaluation of evidence are essential tools for forming well-founded beliefs, and people may differ in the extent to which they apply these tools in their belief formation process.

Organizations around the world are dependent upon active critical thinkers in order to develop, produce, disseminate their goods and services and solve their problems. Managers in a position of creating change within their organizations need to learn, exhibit and teach critical thinking skills to their colleagues and employees. Why?

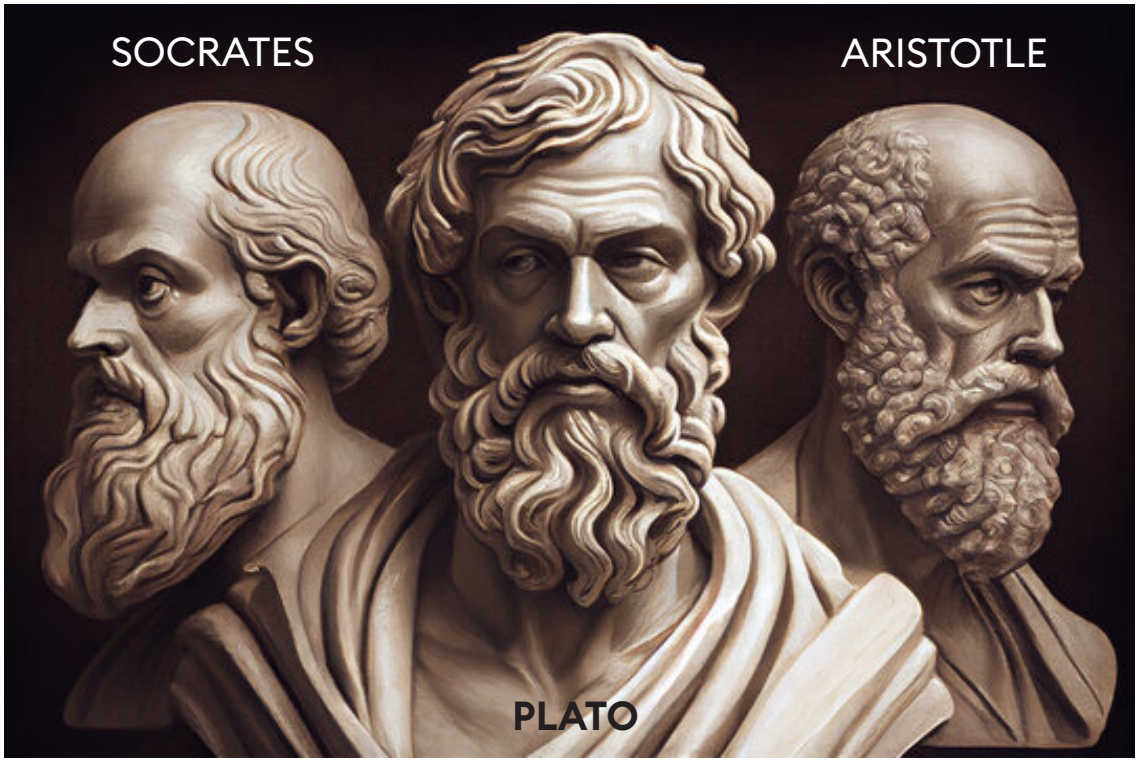
Because making decisions in today's chaotic business world, a world of increasing pressure, uncertainty, conflicting ideas and opinions, creates challenges that managers need to adeptly navigate. Understanding key methods of critical thinking helps managers learn to address the right problems, identify risks and make better decisions.

According to a report from Reboot, 95% of respondents believe that critical thinking skills are vital in today's world. However, 85% believe that these skills are lacking in public. This means that, while critical thinking is a vital skill, very few actually work on building it up.

SO, WHAT IS CRITICAL THINKING ANYWAY?

Critical thinking has been a concept that has evolved over time, and it cannot be attributed to a single individual or group. Instead, it has developed through the contributions of various philosophers, educators and scholars throughout history.

Here are some key figures and movements that have played a role in introducing and promoting critical thinking:



SOCRATES: The ancient Greek philosopher is often considered one of the earliest proponents of critical thinking. He emphasized asking probing questions to stimulate critical examination of ideas and beliefs.

PLATO AND ARISTOTLE: Socrates' students, Plato and Aristotle, further developed the foundations of critical thinking. Plato's Socratic dialogues and Aristotle's writings on logic and argumentation laid the groundwork for later developments in critical thinking.

In essence, critical thinking has evolved over centuries and has been influenced by numerous thinkers, educators, and movements. It continues to be a central aspect of education and intellectual discourse today, with ongoing developments in its theory and practice.

Critical thinking is a cognitive process that entails the active and skillful analysis, evaluation and synthesis of information to form well-reasoned judgments and make informed decisions. It is a disciplined and analytical approach to problem solving and decision-making that transcends the mere acceptance of information at face value. Instead, it involves questioning, examining, and challenging ideas and arguments.

Critical thinking gives one the ability to examine and thoroughly evaluate circumstances, arriving at clever judgments based on facts and reason, using intelligence, knowledge and skills. This valuable analytical approach assists managers and entrepreneurs in considering the desired and unforeseen repercussions of their actions upon their teams and businesses.

In an ever-expanding and multifaceted business landscape, managers are faced with a plethora of challenges stemming from diverse possibilities and perspectives. In order to effectively address these challenges and navigate through the inherent instability, managers must possess the ability to engage in critical thinking. Regrettably, critical thinking has not been accorded the requisite attention as a discipline or as a crucial tool of corporate management, thereby presenting a formidable obstacle to be surmounted.

Key aspects of critical thinking include:

1. objective analysis;
2. evidence-based reasoning;
3. logical reasoning;
4. problem identification;
5. open-mindedness;
6. effective communication; and
7. reflection and self-awareness.

Critical thinking helps individuals avoid hasty judgments, recognize faulty reasoning, and arrive at well-informed conclusions. By fostering critical thinking skills, people can enhance their ability to make sound decisions and develop a deeper understanding of complex issues. Being an effective manager means being a good thinker.

Effective thinking is the amalgamation of critical and creative thinking abilities, principles, routines, and incentives, all of which play a pivotal role in determining the utilization of good thinking skills when they are most required.

The important thing is that thinking dispositions can be taught and learned. Several key thinking temperaments are important for good thinkers. Managers should take note and determine ways to best use them to their advantage in critical situations.

Thinking dispositions pertain to the attitudes, tendencies, and inclinations that individuals possess towards thinking and problem solving. These dispositions exert a significant influence on how people approach and interact with diverse cognitive tasks, such as learning, critical thinking, decision-making, and creative problem solving.

Thinking dispositions are not fixed traits, but rather malleable characteristics that can be developed and improved over time. Here are some common thinking dispositions:

- Open-mindedness;
- Curiosity;
- Intellectual humility: The recognition of one's own limitations and the willingness to acknowledge when one is wrong or lacks knowledge in a particular area. This disposition fosters a receptive and humble approach to learning and engaging with others;
- Reflectiveness;
- Persistence;
- Critical thinking;
- Creativity;
- Empathy;
- Metacognition: The awareness and control of one's own thinking processes; and
- Systems thinking: The ability to understand and analyze complex systems and their interconnected parts.

Promoting positive thinking dispositions can lead to more effective and adaptable problem-solvers, and decision-makers.

Too many managers blunder through their jobs, their lives and their interactions with colleagues and employees without any rhyme or reason. Taking time to organize your thinking will go a long way toward helping you be more productive and efficient while at the same time, improving your overall relationships with the people with whom you are in daily con- tact.

This can take different forms for different people. For some, journaling one's thoughts, actions, hopes and dreams can be beneficial.

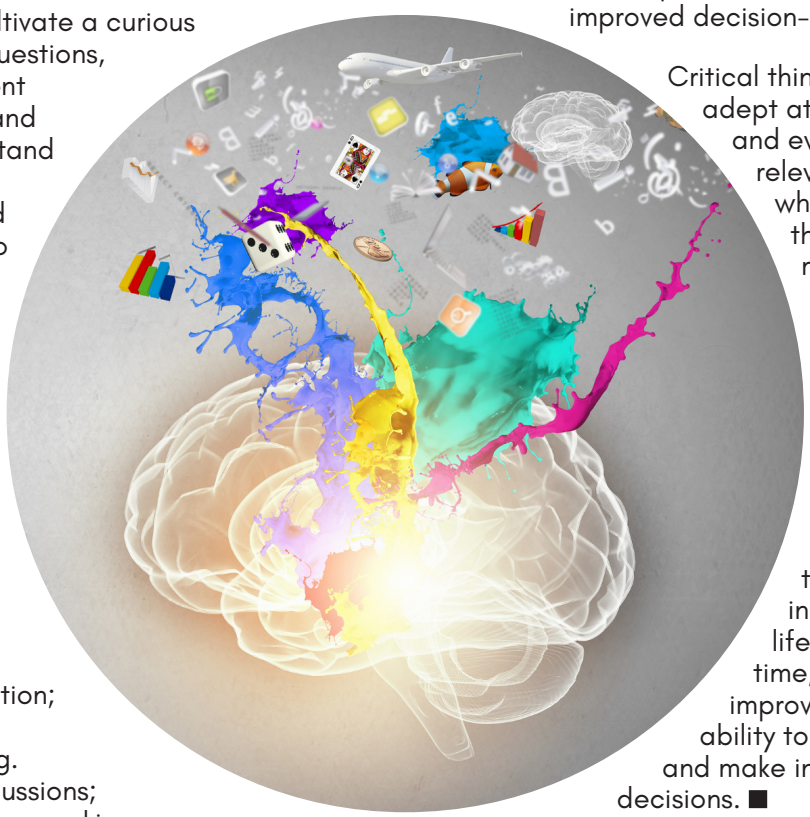
Notetaking, to-do lists, personal digital assistants (PDA) and specialized desktop software can all be mechanisms for organizing thinking. David Allen's wildly popular book Getting Things Done describes a detailed method of organizing one's work, which works in tandem with organizing thought. Regardless of what method you choose, find a way to organize your thought processes and you will find yourself one step closer to better organization in your life and in turn, peace of mind.

Other critical question will be, "Can I learn it?" Absolutely, you can learn and develop critical thinking skills. Critical thinking is the ability to analyze, evaluate and synthesize information in a logical and systematic manner to make

reasoned decisions and solve problems. It is an essential skill that can be applied to various aspects of life, including academics, work, and personal decisions.
Here are some steps you can take to enhance your critical thinking skills:

- Be curious: Cultivate a curious mindset. Ask questions, explore different perspectives, and seek to understand the underlying reasons behind things. Learn to look beyond the surface;
- Gather information;
- Analyze information;
- Evaluate sources;
- Consider multiple perspectives;
- Question assumptions;
- Practice reflection; and
- Problem solving.
- Engage in discussions;
- Practice decision-making;
- Learn from mistakes;
- Read widely; and
- Solve puzzles and brain teasers.

In a fast-paced and dynamic business environment, critical thinking skills empower individuals to assess complex situations, identify potential risks and opportunities, and develop effective strategies. Employers value critical thinkers who can evaluate information objectively, challenge assumptions, and propose innovative solutions. By employing critical thinking, employees can approach challenges with a logical and systematic mindset, leading to more efficient problem-solving and improved decision-making.



Critical thinkers are also adept at gathering and evaluating relevant data, which enhances their ability to make informed judgments.

Remember that developing critical thinking skills takes time and practice. Start by applying these strategies in your everyday life, and over time, you will notice improvements in your ability to think critically and make informed decisions. ■

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